

## Early Heian court tales

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In modern parlance, the term *monogatari* (variously translated in English as tale, romance, novel) refers to relatively long prose narratives, chiefly concerning relations between aristocratic men and women, told in the equivalent of the third person, and produced among the nobility from the early tenth century until some time in the Kamakura period (1185–1333). This chapter traces the emergence of this genre up until the appearance of *The Tale of Genji* in the early eleventh century, which marks its pinnacle.

The earliest extant *monogatari* is traditionally taken to be *Taketori monogatari* (The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter, c. 909), called in *Genji* “the parent of literary romances first to come out” (*monogatari no ideki-hajime no oya*). Some scholars believe the present work to be a rewriting of an earlier version; the present text is believed to have come into existence between 810 and 910.

Elements of the *Taketori* resemble some of the tales or myths found in the *Nihon shoki* (or *Nihongi*; Chronicles of Japan, 720), and the *fudoki*, or local gazetteers, originally ordered from each province by Empress Genmei in 713. Each province was to provide accounts of its topographical and other natural features, along with legends concerning local sites of significance. *Tango fudoki* includes the legend of Nagu Shrine, which is similar to the basic *Taketori* story, being a version of the “swan-maiden” tale that is found throughout East Asia, in which a heavenly maiden is robbed of her feather-robe and married to a mortal or raised by a mortal couple.

In addition to folklore, however, Heian Japan was obviously aware of the short fiction that circulated in Tang China. The most influential was perhaps *You xianku* (J. *Yūsenkutsu*), or *A Dalliance in the Immortals' Den*. Probably written by Zhang Zhou (c. 657–730), it is a first-person account in which the protagonist happens upon the dwelling of a widow and woos her with poetry and humor, facilitated by another woman, who serves as a kind of go-between. The piece ends with a fairly explicit description of the principals

making love, followed by a variety of poems concerning the sadness of parting.

Influence from the *You xianku* can be seen as early as the eighth-century *Man'yōshū*, in such pieces as the “Excursion to Matsura River” (5: 857–63), which was also influenced by the narrative poem *Luo-shen fu* (Rhyme-Prose on the Goddess of the Lo River). *Man'yōshū* also includes several other narrative tales, especially in Book Sixteen, including a version with an old bamboo cutter and nine “heavenly maidens.” In all these stories, the basic theme is the meeting of a man with heavenly maidens who, often by means of some kind of magical food or drink, are capable of offering immortality.

### *Taketori monogatari* (The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter)

Elixirs of immortality also underlie *The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter*. An old man discovers a radiant girl, three inches high, in the bamboo he gathers. After taking her home to raise, the old man starts finding gold in the bamboo he collects, and becomes rich. The girl continues to shine, and the mere sight of her lifts the old man's spirits.

Eventually, having grown to full size in a matter of months, the girl becomes the object of romantic interest for five aristocratic suitors. Scholars since the Edo period have attempted to match the names of the five suitors with specific historical individuals, especially Prince Kuramochi with Fujiwara no Fuhito (659–720), the second son of the founder of the Fujiwara clan, Fujiwara (formerly Nakatomi) no Kamatari (614–69). Given the parodic treatment of the suitors, such identifications can lead to a political reading of the *Taketori*: that it is a criticism of the Fujiwara *sekkon-ke*, or “Regents' House,” and their clients, and especially their control of the imperial family through intermarriage.

The heroine of *Taketori*, The Shining Princess (Kaguya-hime), sets five individual and seemingly impossible tasks for her suitors to test their devotion. Regardless of any political implications, the objects sought are all magical: the stone begging-bowl of the Buddha, a jeweled branch from Mount Penglai (J. Hōrai), a robe made of fire-rat skin, impervious to flames, a jewel from the neck of a dragon, and an easy-birthing charm.

The five suitors fail, much to Kaguya-hime's delight. With each she exchanges poems at the moment of their defeat, and each of the suitors' episodes ends with a facetious etymology for some expression; for example,

Prince Kuramochi throws away the stone bowl (*hachi o sutsu*) after it is discovered to be a fraud, and is said to also discard his shame (*haji o sutsu*).

The emperor then learns of Kaguya-hime and attempts to win her. She refuses him as well, but does engage in a regular romantic correspondence that is said to comfort them both (*tagai ni nagusamu*). Increasingly depressed, Kaguya-hime reveals to her adopted parents that she is in fact from the moon – as a result of committing some sin she was exiled to earth for a period of time. But her sentence is coming to an end, and the moon-people will soon be coming to bring her back. The old bamboo cutter alerts the emperor, who dispatches two thousand warriors to repulse the moon-people, but when the celestial troupe arrives the soldiers are unable to resist, the doors to the dwelling open of their own accord, and Kaguya-hime floats into the sky to rejoin her people. We are told that once she dons her feathered robe, she will forget all about the earth and the people on it, once more free from any kind of pain or suffering. But beforehand she writes letters of farewell and regret to both her parents and the emperor, accompanied by containers of the elixir of immortality. Both the parents and the emperor refuse the elixir, the emperor going so far as to have it, and a final poem to her, taken to the top of the mountain “closest to heaven” – Mount Fuji (which itself is said to mean “no death”) – and burned, accounting for the smoke that at the time still rose from the peak.

In the Tang dynasty, many stories and poems circulated about the meetings of the emperors Mu (343–61) and Wu (236–90) with the Queen Mother of the West (Xi Wang Mu). In these texts, the emperors approach the queen mother to be taught the secrets of Taoist alchemy and to obtain an elixir of immortality, though they ultimately fail or are refused. Significantly, in *Taketori*, it is the emperor who refuses the elixir he is given by the female immortal, choosing instead to live in sorrow, remembering his love. Such a conclusion seems a powerful rejection of the Taoist search to transcend life and mortality, and a strong affirmation of the value of human sentiment. The tale also marks the first appearance of several durable motifs, including the exile of a young noble (*kishu ryūri*), and the woman who will not marry (repeated as Ōigimi and Ukifune in *Genji*).

### *Ise monogatari* and other poem-tales

The influence of Tang literature continued in Japanese vernacular fiction and poetry after *Taketori*. *The Ise Stories* is a collection of 125 anecdotes, centered around exchanges of poetry, typically between a man and a woman. The

work is attributed to Ariwara no Narihira (825–80), but was added to and adapted by many hands, not reaching its “definitive” state until the 1234 *Tenpuku-bon* edited by Fujiwara no Teika (1162–1241). Nonetheless, at the core of the collection lies a number of stories and poems composed by Narihira. The most important of these is the tale that gives the collection its name, where the unnamed protagonist visits Ise Shrine as an imperial envoy and spends a night making love to the Ise Priestess. Elements of the story seem to have been drawn from the Tang short vernacular tale *Ying-ying zhuan* (The Story of Ying-ying). There are also several exchanges of poems that resemble the seemingly passionate homosocial verse of poets such as Bo Juyi. On the other hand, many of the episodes are reminiscent of similar narrativized exchanges of poems between spouses collected in Book Sixteen of the *Man'yōshū*. Finally, the anecdotes seem to be given as exemplars of courtly behavior (*miyabi*), much as many of the anecdotes of the fifth-century *Shishuo xinyu* (New Tales of the World, J. *Sesetsu shingo*) exemplify the principle of *ziran* (J. *shizen*; “naturalness”) and its associated concept of *fengliu* (J. *fūryū*), which was itself sometimes translated as *miyabi*, or “courtliness.”

*Ise* also picks up on the motif of exile that was present in *Taketori*, this time with an undeniably political context: the protagonist has relations with a woman promised to the crown prince. Upon discovery, he decides that a tactical removal to the hinterlands is in order. The political interpretation can also be taken further, seeing Narihira's interference with Fujiwara marriage politics as an overtly political attempt to break that clan's monopoly on providing consorts to the imperial house. Regardless, it is no doubt significant that the locus of “courtliness” (*miyabi*) as depicted is centered not on the Fujiwara-controlled imperial court, but among the salons of the politically disenfranchised.

*Ise* has many poems, and narrative sections, in common with the first imperially commissioned anthology of Japanese poetry, *Kokin wakashū*, or Collection of Ancient and Modern Poems (c. 905–14); it is believed that both *Ise* and *Kokinshū* derived these episodes from a common source. The narrative impulse is even more pronounced in the second imperial anthology, *Gosenshū* (Collection of Later Gleanings, 951) compiled by the “The Pear Court Five” (*Nashitsubo no Gonin*), who included Kiyowara no Motosuke (908–90) and Minamoto no Shitagō (911–83). Many of the headnotes to poems in *Gosenshū* are relatively extended narratives, as in *Ise*, which also underwent expansion at this time.

Starting with *Ise* and *Gosenshū*, the second half of the tenth century sees an explosion in vernacular fiction. *Yamato monogatari* (Tales of Yamato) centers

around the court and salon of Retired Emperor Uda (867–931, r. 887–97). Uda attempted to escape Fujiwara control by abdicating in favor of his young son, Daigo (885–930, r. 897–930), and balancing Fujiwara no Tokihira (871–909), Minister of the Left, with Sugawara no Michizane (845–903) as Minister of the Right. By 901, however, Tokihira had engineered Michizane's banishment and Daigo remained thoroughly under Fujiwara control. In *Yamato*, though, the Fujiwara are conspicuous by their absence, and some have suggested that it was compiled in reaction to the inclusion of so many Fujiwara in *Gosenshū*.

*Heichū monogatari* was produced some time before 965. It too can be read as a manifestation of anti-Fujiwara discontent. The protagonist is Taira no Sadafun (d. 923), someone known principally as a poet from the *Kokinshū* period (he has nine poems included in that anthology). *Heichū* (a nickname for Sadafun of partially obscure origin) is a collection of thirty-nine episodes, focusing, much like *Ise*, on his pursuit of various women. Unlike Narihira, however, Heichū is comically unsuccessful. It is this very lack of success that can be seen as a critique of the Fujiwara-dominated court; as Susan Videen writes: "The author of *Tales of Heichū* takes a man of noble birth, who has a reputation as a sensitive poet and lover; of all men, he seems to be saying, this one should be a success in life and love. And yet by painting Heichū as a failure, he conveys the ironic truth that, in his day and age, talent and depth of feelings are not what really matter" (28–9). The sekkan-ke responded to the challenge of both *Ise* and *Heichū*, in Fujiwara no Koremasa (also read Koretada, 924–72) and his "Tale of Toyokage" (970–71), a fictional persona who is of low rank like Heichū and Narihira, but, unlike them, does not pursue politically inappropriate women, and yet does succeed with the ladies, despite his status. Koremasa was the steward (*bettō*) of the Poetry Bureau (*waka-dokoro*) during the compilation of *Gosenshū*, which may account for his interest in new narrative forms.

Some of the poems and events in *Toyokage* appeared earlier in *Gosenshū* under Koremasa's name, and all the events are thought to be drawn from his life. The poems are meant to be understood as being sent as, or with, letters, so it is not surprising to see the appearance around this time of what may be thought of as an epistolary novel, the *Tōnomine Shōshō monogatari* (see chapter 15 below, "Heian literary diaries"). The figure of an aristocratic male, longing to renounce the world despite attachments to family, will recur throughout the monogatari corpus.

### *Tsukuri-monogatari*

As can be seen from the above, genre boundaries were very fluid in this period, and the same work might be labeled a "tale" (*monogatari*) or a

“diary/journal” (*nikki*), or even “poetry collection” (*shū*). Modern scholars identify most of these works, from *Ise monogatari* to *Tōnomine Shōshō monogatari*, as *uta-monogatari*, or “poem-tales” – essentially collections of poems with brief, contextualizing prose. It is not until the proportion of prose to poems becomes significantly greater that a new genre is recognized by modern scholars, namely *tsukuri-monogatari*, or “made-up tales.” The earliest extant example, after *Taketori*, is *Utsuho monogatari*, a work that seems to combine all the elements discussed so far. The first of twenty books is a fantastic tale, along the lines of *Taketori*, of one Kiyohara no Toshikage becoming shipwrecked on his way to China and meeting various magical beings – including the Buddha! – and finally being given thirty *koto* (a kind of floor harp) and mystical instruction in their playing, before eventually making his way back to Japan. The remaining nineteen chapters, however, mostly eschew the supernatural and focus on the many suitors of a young woman, Atemiya, including one of her full brothers, Nakazumi; and then on political matters after she is given to the crown prince and bears him several princes, but is unsure whether her eldest son will be designated crown prince when her husband becomes emperor. The narrative then turns back to focus on Nakatada, the grandson of the now-deceased Toshikage, who passes on the musical secrets of his mother and himself to his young daughter. The novel comes to an end with a grand concert at Nakatada’s Kyōgoku residence, where his mother, his daughter, and he himself perform for two retired emperors and many high-ranking courtiers, their music causing thunder, lightning, and other celestial disturbances. All present are moved to tears and the work concludes with a round of promotions for Nakatada’s family.

The manuscripts of *Utsuho* include a large number of irregularly positioned captions (around 130) for illustrations that are no longer extant, suggesting they may represent some draft stage. Tamagami Takuya argued that *monogatari* were always illustrated and that, until the *Genji*, the pictures were in fact more important than the text. *Utsuho* is traditionally attributed to Minamoto no Shitagō, one of the compilers of *Gosenshū*, though there is no conclusive evidence. The work appears to have been written over a number of years, commencing perhaps in the year 969 and concluding around 982. The text includes a great number of poetry exchanges, including those at formal events, when a string of some twenty verses will be “recorded.” In fact, Marie J. Mueller has suggested that some of the sense of “realism” that *Utsuho* seems to manifest may be due to the author’s use of the style of recording diaries, which were made for occasions such as poetry contests

(p. 164). Poems are also exchanged through letters, but there is now a greater degree of dialogue between characters than seen in earlier works. But what is most remarkable about *Utsuho* in comparison to earlier works is its length: a modern edition runs three book-length volumes. The vernacular had now proven itself capable of truly sustained narrative.

Somewhat shorter is *Ochikubo monogatari*, the final extant monogatari dating from before *The Tale of Genji*. This is a very traditional tale of the Cinderella type, the origins of which have been traced back to ninth-century China. Chūnagon (Middle Counselor) has once been married to an imperial princess, who has given him one beautiful daughter. The mother has died, however, and he is now married to another woman, with whom he has several daughters and sons. The first daughter lives with her father, stepmother, and half-siblings. She is, however, mistreated by her stepmother, who fears her superior looks and character will be detrimental to the marriage prospects of her own daughters. She therefore treats her stepdaughter like a servant, relegating her to a kind of basement suite, or *ochikubo*, and the girl becomes known as Lady Ochikubo. Ochikubo has one devoted servant, who becomes involved with the retainer of a Lesser Captain, Michiyori. Michiyori is in fact the son of Sadaishō (General of the Left), and his sister is the emperor's favorite consort. Michiyori is not yet married, and his retainer, Korenari, one day tells him of Ochikubo's plight. Michiyori and Ochikubo start a relationship that is eventually discovered by the wicked stepmother. Michiyori is at last able to steal the girl away, and installs her in his residence as his principal wife.

The remainder of the tale divides into two halves: in the first, Michiyori takes revenge on Ochikubo's family for all the indignities it inflicted on her – for example, stealing their room at Kiyomizu Temple during a pilgrimage, and so forcing them to sleep in their carriages, which are said to be more cramped than the basement room Ochikubo had been confined to. In the second half, he compensates them for all the mischief he has done, reuniting Ochikubo with her father, and providing promotions and good marriages to all her half-siblings. True to the imperial bride-stealing motif, Michiyori's daughter eventually gives birth to a crown prince.

Like *Taketori* and *Utsuho*, the author of *Ochikubo* is believed to have been a man, writing for a presumably female readership. The appeal of a rags-to-riches story of a mistreated stepdaughter is apparent, and *Ochikubo* also includes a number of pronouncements against polygyny. The tale proceeds as if it is due to Ochikubo's good fortune that the captain's family succeeds politically, finally placing Ochikubo's daughters as chief consorts to both the

emperor and the crown prince, though in fact this success is actually due to typical marriage politics. Ochikubo's good fortune is due to her imperial blood, and she is the first of a number of misplaced imperial progeny whose return to their "proper" social level will be the focus of later romances, such as *The Tale of Genji*.